

media centre. You might not get the big-theatre experience while watching a movie on a 17-inch LCD screen, but for everything else, it works just as fine.

Another option in solving the media centre puzzle is the IPTV, or Internet Protocol Television. Revolutions in television broadcast such as TiVo and video-on-demand has pushed IPTV to the forefront and made it a strong contender as the centre of your media hub. It has also made it imperative that you merge your data and entertainment centre. With this merger, you can now watch live and recorded TV broadcasts, movies, browse through a library of digital photos, and stream MP3 music to your audio system - all from a central location. The idea is, in effect, to create a media centre that can store all your data (television programmes, movies etc.), act as your workspace, and also as a home theatre.

Electronics companies are coming up with high definition LCD TVs that can access networks via broadband. These televisions can browse and play data stored on your computer's hard drive - this will give you the necessary freedom to separate your workspace from your entertainment needs.

So would you lean towards a 17-inch LCD or CRT monitor, a stand alone 29-inch television, or a projection TV - or would it be the new age IPTV? As of today, in India, with broadband technology yet to get to the end user and with the cable television industry unregulated, it is best to de-link your workspace from your entertainment centre. A TV with network access capabilities and one that can directly access your hard disk via a home network seems to fit the bill quite well. This ensures that the big screen television can be used in one room while you work on a presentation on your computer and yet watch movies stored on your hard disk on the big screen TV when it catches your fancy.

That is what we call the perfect media hub. Of course there's a price you'll pay, and we are talking hard cash. How much?